

AUTONATEAI

Events & Build Radar

9 September 2026

The strongest move is not another broad conference search. It is a three-step sequence: register for Microsoft's Architect track, enter the GSA MCP/agent build community, and reserve NASA Space Apps as the map-plus-simulation flagship.

California-first technical events, competitions, people, communities, and build pathways.

Executive brief

The immediate calendar has a clean progression from skill-building to relationship-building to public proof. Microsoft's September 17 Agent-a-Thon offers a virtual Architect track for production-grade agent orchestration and secure enterprise workflows.¹ Stanford HAI follows with a September 30 hybrid seminar on world models and spatial intelligence—directly aligned with GIS, simulation, robotics, and infrastructure planning.² NASA Space Apps then provides a November 14–15 global build deadline, California local events, a universal virtual route, and teams of up to six.³

The best competition wedge is GSA's virtual 2026 MCP Server and AI Agent Hackathon. Its official page confirms a September–November window and limited space, but does not yet publish exact session dates, team size, prizes, judging, or eligibility.⁴ That uncertainty is a reason to register, not a license to invent details.

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Priority stack

1 Register and build now

Microsoft Architect track + GSA MCP/agent hackathon. Use one coherent concept across both: a provenance-first public-procurement intelligence agent with read-only retrieval, explicit confidence labels, deduplication, and a separate human-approved write boundary.

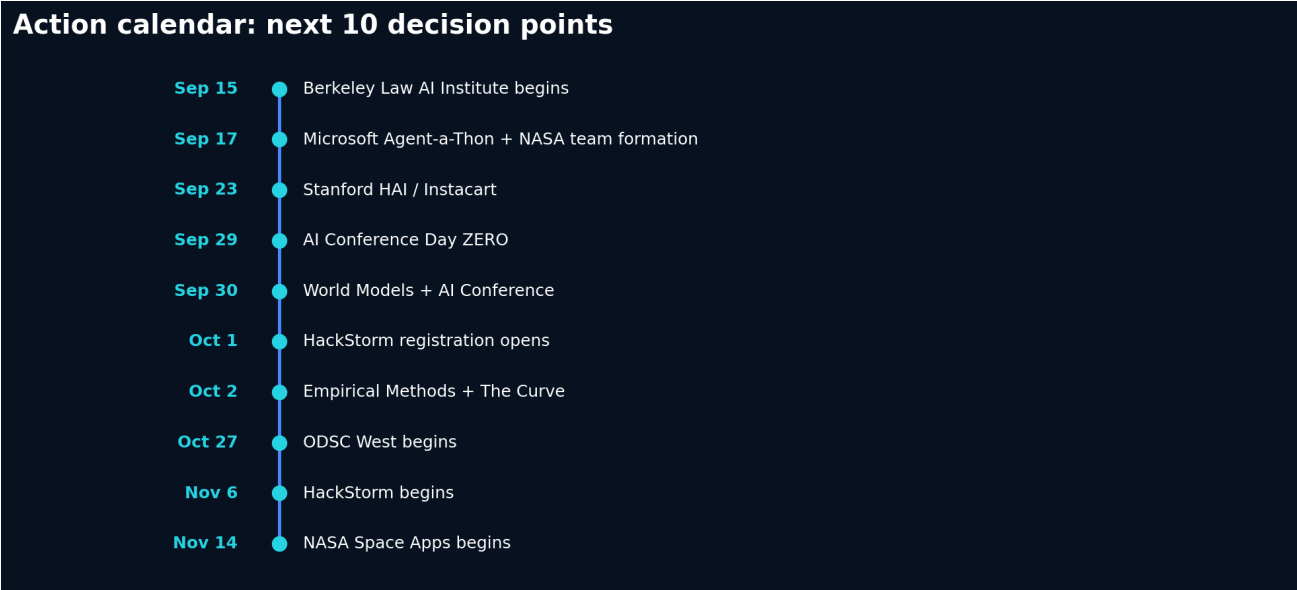
2 Build relationship context

Attend Stanford's Instacart/AI-diffusion conversation on September 23 and world-model seminar on September 30. Ask narrow questions rooted in public work; do not pitch generic consulting.

3 Ship a public artifact

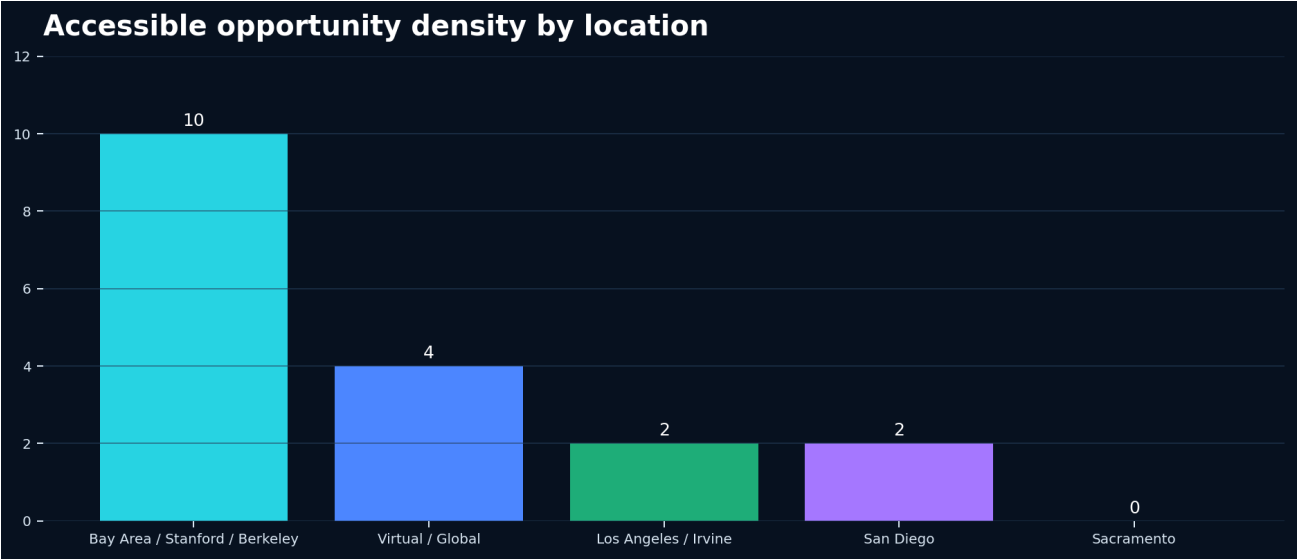
Use NASA Space Apps as the deadline for a map-first decision simulator. Wait for the official challenge statements before locking the problem, then connect the build to a short methods publication and a focused follow-up list.

Combined calendar and decision timeline



DATE	OPPORTUNITY	MODE / LOCATION	DECISION
Sep 15-17	UC Berkeley Law AI Institute	Berkeley + livestream	Use livestream; study governance-to-controls translation.
Sep 17	Microsoft Agent-a-Thon — Architect	Virtual; 11 AM-2 PM ET	Register today; bring one architecture concept.
Sep-Nov	GSA MCP Server + AI Agent Hackathon	Virtual; exact sessions TBD	Register now; space is limited.
Sep 23	Stanford HAI / Instacart	Stanford + virtual; noon PT	Attend virtually; ask an AI-work-design question.
Sep 29-Oct 1	The AI Conference + Day ZERO	Pier 48, San Francisco	Travel only if budget supports targeted meetings.
Sep 30	World Models & Spatial Intelligence	Stanford + virtual; 3 PM PT	Attend; prepare a map/simulation question.
Oct 1	HackStorm registration opens	Bay Area	Set reminder; decide after hardware/challenge details.
Oct 2	Empirical Methods in the Age of AI	Stanford; details emerging	Track program and participation route.
Oct 2-4	The Curve	Berkeley; invitation-only	Apply only with a contribution-led concept.
Oct 27-29	ODSC West	Burlingame	Watch speaker updates; target data/agent sessions.
Nov 6-8	HackStorm Physical AI Hackathon	Bay Area	Enter if a hardware/simulation concept is ready.
Nov 14-15	NASA Space Apps	LA/Irvine/Universal virtual	Flagship map + simulation build deadline.

California geographic breakdown



Counts reflect the selected radar set, not total market size. Bay Area density is high because Stanford, Berkeley, San Francisco, Burlingame, and the physical-AI community all have verified near-term activity.

REGION	VERIFIED SIGNALS	INTERPRETATION / MOVE
San Francisco / Bay Area	The AI Conference, Day ZERO, ODSC West, HackStorm, Stanford HAI seminars, Berkeley Law AI Institute, The Curve	Best relationship density. Use hybrid/virtual routes first; travel only around preselected people and sessions.
Los Angeles / Orange County	NASA Space Apps local events in Los Angeles and Irvine . ¹⁷¹⁸	Best Southern California build route. Choose the local node only after comparing schedule, venue, and organizer updates.
San Diego	Science of Consciousness and Berkeley/California neurotechnology connections already tracked; no stronger new general software build signal qualified today.	Keep in the rotation for neurotech, defense, biotech, and university events; do not pad the daily brief with weak listings.
San Jose / Santa Clara	Recent API + Cloud + AI hackathon ended September 3; no selected open replacement qualified in this run.	Monitor enterprise developer events and AI infrastructure communities; require an open registration or submission route.
Sacramento	No high-value verified new event selected today.	Continue scanning state-government, GIS, civic-tech, and university calendars.

Top events to attend or register for

1 Microsoft Agent-a-Thon — Architect

September 17 · virtual · 11:00 AM–2:00 PM ET. The official track covers orchestration, multi-agent systems, secure enterprise workflows, and Microsoft Foundry.¹ Action: register today and bring a four-box architecture: retrieval, verifier, human approval, audit log. Cost: not stated on the reviewed page.

2 World Models & Spatial Intelligence

September 30 · Stanford + virtual · 3:00–4:15 PM PT. Speakers include Jiajun Wu and Daniel Zhang; topics include infrastructure planning, crisis response, scientific experimentation, and embodied AI.² Action: attend virtually with one map/simulation evaluation question. Cost: not stated.

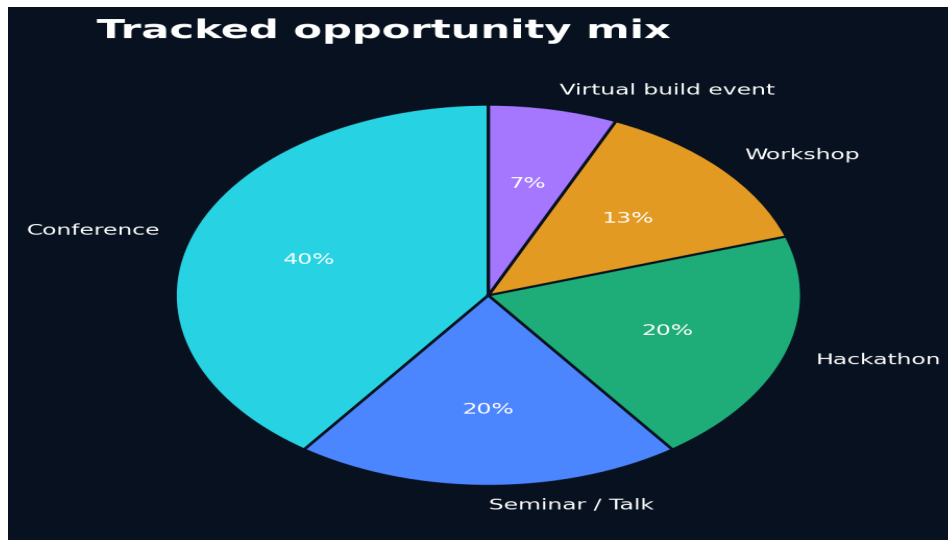
3 The AI Conference / Day ZERO

September 29–October 1 · Pier 48, San Francisco. The official site lists 5,500+ attendees and 120+ speakers; Day ZERO is capped at 350 and focuses on RAG, infrastructure, evaluation, agents, and deployment.⁵⁶ Action: go only with meetings and a live demo. Cost: tickets are on sale, but a reliable live price was not exposed in the text reviewed.

Secondary event plays

Attend the September 23 Stanford HAI/Instacart conversation virtually for AI diffusion and organizational-design context.⁷ Use the Berkeley Law AI Institute livestream for governance-to-software-control translation.⁸ Track ODSC West for data infrastructure and production-AI sessions, but do not travel until the speaker/session fit is concrete.⁹

Top build opportunities



1 GSA provenance-first procurement MCP

Why now: official virtual hackathon, September–November, limited space.⁴ Build: read-only connectors for public notices; canonical-URL deduplication; source/date extraction; confidence labels; POC graph; human-approved Airtable write. Submission risk: exact dates, rules, team size, judging, and prizes remain unpublished—register before committing a full sprint.

2 NASA geospatial decision simulator

Why now: registration is open; November 14–15; teams up to six; California and universal virtual routes.³ Build: select an official challenge after release, ingest NASA data, show map layers and uncertainty, simulate a changing condition, and generate source-grounded explanations. Do not: pick a problem before the 2026 challenge statements are official.

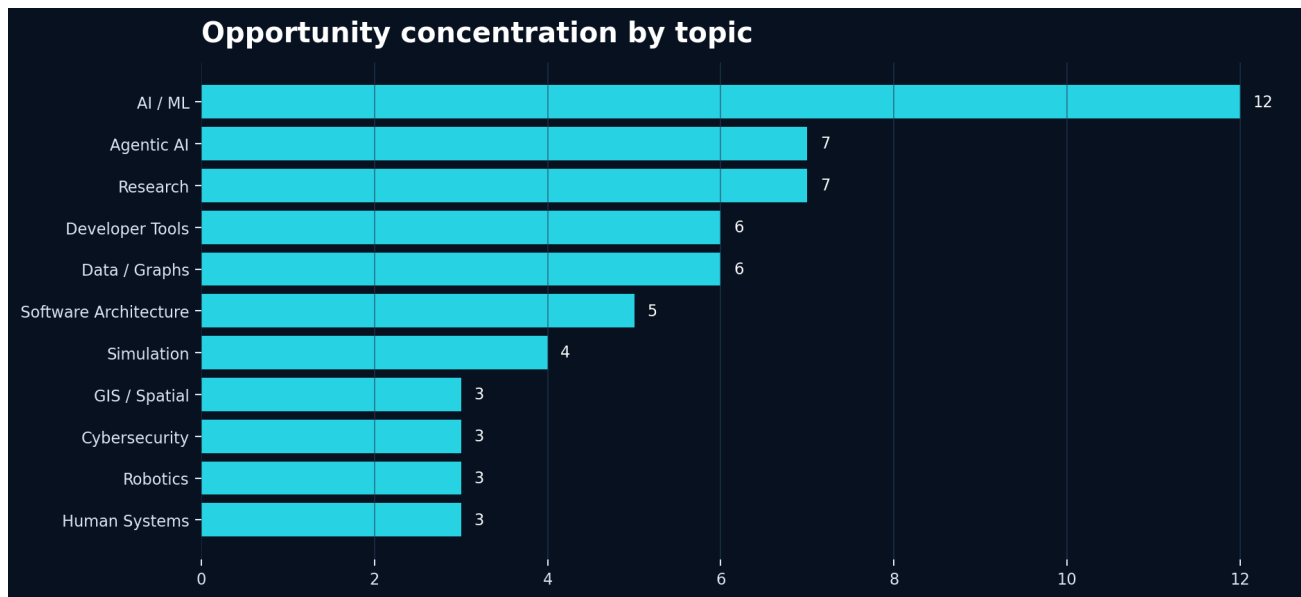
3 HackStorm physical-AI test harness

Why now: November 6–8 Bay Area physical-AI hackathon; registration opens October 1.¹⁰ Build: a synthetic-sensor replay and evaluation dashboard for a mobile agent, with mission state, faults, recovery, and operator handoff. Optional Athena connection: non-clinical attention/interaction signals may change interface pacing, never safety-critical control.

What to build: realistic scopes and inputs

BUILD	48-HOUR CORE	POSSIBLE INPUTS	PUBLIC OUTPUT
Procurement MCP	Search 2-3 official sources; normalize notices; show provenance; human-approved export.	SAM.gov/public APIs; agency RSS/pages; OpenViking or Semantica for memory/provenance; Codex for implementation.	Repo + 3-minute demo + threat/authority model.
NASA map simulator	One official challenge; one dataset; 2-3 layers; one scenario change; uncertainty panel.	Official NASA challenge resources; Mapbox/Deck.gl; open geospatial tooling; lightweight agent for explanations.	Interactive demo + methods note + data lineage page.
Physical-AI harness	Recorded/synthetic sensor stream; state machine; fault injection; replay; operator override.	ROS bags or synthetic streams; Godot/Blender simulation; Python event pipeline; graph-based test cases.	Repo + replay video + evaluation rubric.
Agent-control demo	Retriever, verifier, planner, approval gate, write worker, immutable event log.	Microsoft Foundry workshop materials; OpenViking; Semantica; context-mode; browser-use-pi.	Architecture diagram + runnable vertical slice.

The reusable idea is the control plane: every build should expose source identity, state transitions, confidence, permissions, and human handoff. That is the AutoNateAI signature across public procurement, spatial simulation, physical AI, and agent workflows.



People to know and questions worth asking

PERSON	PUBLIC ROLE / CONNECTION	VALUE-FIRST QUESTION
Jiajun Wu	Stanford CS; computer vision, robotics, physical reasoning	What low-cost simulated environment most reliably exposes whether a world model understands causality rather than reconstructing scenes?
Peter Norvig	Stanford HAI; AI education and applied research	What evaluation evidence best separates a genuinely useful agent from a persuasive but brittle demo?
Emmanuel Ameisen	Anthropic interpretability researcher	What interpretability technique can a small engineering team realistically operationalize in agent regression testing today?
Arvind Karunakaran	Stanford MS&E; authority, accountability, work, AI	Which handoffs become more important—not less—when agents absorb execution work, and how should teams preserve responsibility closure?
Daniel Zhang	Stanford HAI; world-model policy speaker	How should governance distinguish simulated competence from real-world reliability when world models inform infrastructure or crisis decisions?

Engagement sequence

Read one public artifact first. Ask one narrow question. Share a diagram, benchmark, or prototype only when it advances that exact conversation. Follow up within 48 hours with a link and one sentence about what changed in your thinking. The goal is not proximity to a famous person; it is repeated technical usefulness.

Organizations and recurring communities

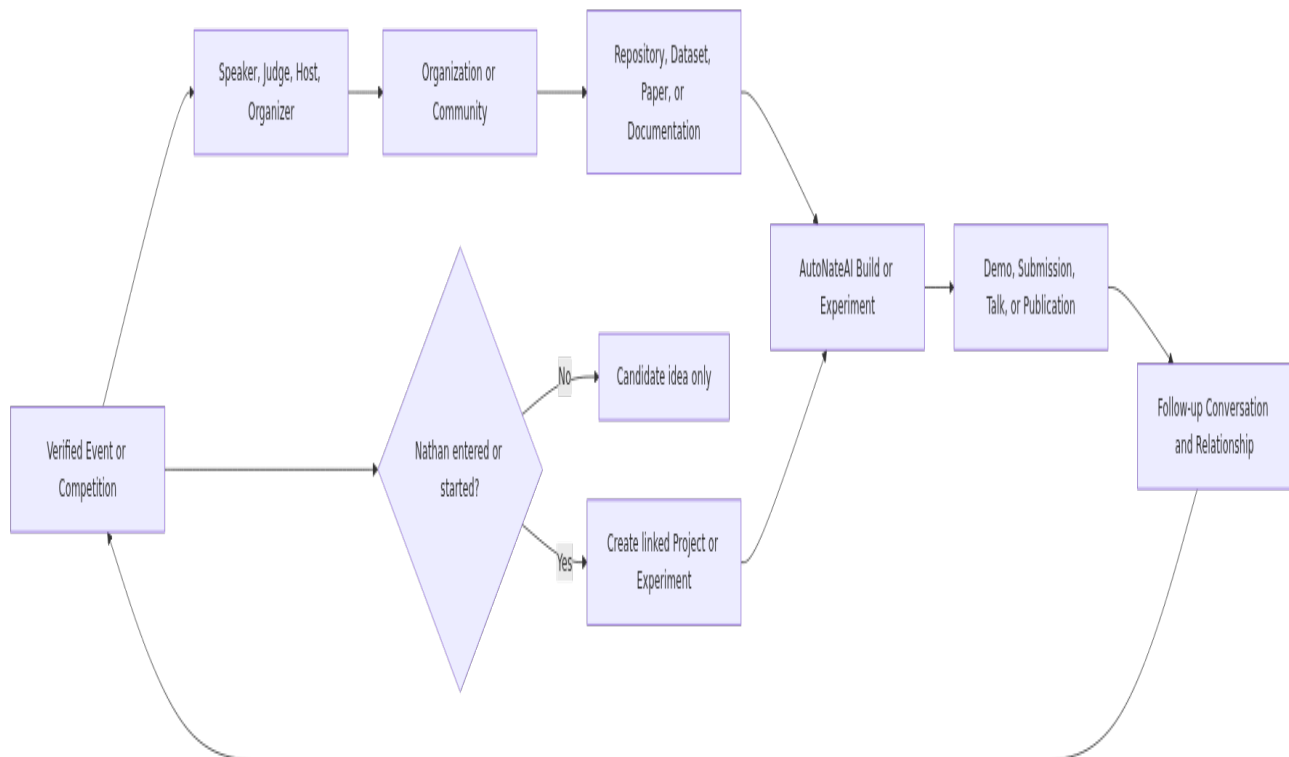
COMMUNITY	WHY IT MATTERS	NEXT MOVE
Stanford HAI	Recurring hybrid seminars; strongest accessible California research node.	Subscribe, attend Sep 23 and Sep 30, track weekly seminar calendar.
The AI Conference	Applied AI, infrastructure, agents, startup demos, 120+ speakers.	Watch weekly speaker updates; decide travel around 3-5 targets.
NASA Space Apps	Global recurring build community with California local nodes.	Register; form/join team after Sep 17; wait for official challenges.
GSA AI Community of Practice	Federal MCP/agent build pathway and public-sector community.	Register; lead with provenance, authority boundaries, and usability.
HackStorm	Physical AI, AIoT, robotics, supplied hardware and workshops.	Prepare concept now; register Oct 1 if track details fit.
ODSC	Recurring data science, engineering, open-source, and production AI community.	Track West agenda; target one workshop and two speakers.
Microsoft Agent-a-Thon	Global skill ladder from explorer to production architect.	Use Architect track as build rehearsal and ecosystem entry.

Ways to speak, demo, host, or collaborate

Host: run a 45-minute virtual ‘NASA Space Apps Build Clinic’ in late October after challenge statements are public. Demo: publish a five-minute world-model uncertainty demo within one week of Stanford’s September 30 seminar. Collaborate: recruit one domain researcher and one designer/data storyteller for Space Apps; keep the team under the official six-person limit. Speak: prepare a short talk proposal on provenance and human approval in agent systems, but submit only when a verified CFP or organizer invitation exists. Community: offer an open methods debrief after the GSA hackathon instead of a generic promotional webinar.

Event → relationship → publication pathway

The diagram below is rendered from the Mermaid source used for the radar workflow. Airtable creates Projects or Experiments only after Nathan has actually entered or started a build.



Mechanics

1. Verify the canonical event page, organizer, date, access route, and constraints.
2. Link public people and organizations.
3. Pull only the repositories, papers, datasets, or documentation that materially change the build.
4. Create a candidate scope outside Projects.
5. On entry/start, create the linked Project or Experiment.
6. Ship a demo or submission with a methods note.
7. Follow up with the people whose public work shaped the design.

Actions today

1 Register: Microsoft Architect track

Use the [official Agent-a-Thon page](#). Choose Americas, Level 3: Architect, September 17, 11:00 AM–2:00 PM ET. Add the session to your calendar.

2 Register interest: GSA MCP + AI Agent Hackathon

Use the [official GSA page](#). Space is limited. Do not wait for prizes or exact team rules before expressing interest.

3 Register: NASA Space Apps

Create an account through the [official 2026 participant page](#). Compare Los Angeles, Irvine, and Universal virtual events. Team formation begins September 17; team size is capped at six.

4 Reserve two Stanford virtual sessions

September 23: [Instacart industry conversation](#). September 30: [world models and spatial intelligence](#). Draft one public-work-based question for each.

5 Create the reusable concept card

One page: user, decision, official sources, agent roles, authority boundaries, audit trail, 48-hour demo, and one measurable evaluation. Reuse this card across Microsoft, GSA, and NASA; change the problem layer, not the control-plane discipline.

Airtable status

This run added eight verified events, eight event/build sources, eight organizations, and five people; corrected The AI Conference start date to include Day ZERO; linked existing HackStorm and ODSC records; and intentionally created no Project or Experiment records.

Sources

Official and authoritative pages were preferred. Unknown prices, schedules, prizes, deadlines, eligibility, speakers, or availability are labeled rather than inferred.

1. Microsoft. [Microsoft Agent-a-Thon](#). 2026.
2. Stanford HAI. [The World Model and Spatial Intelligence Era](#). 2026.
3. NASA Space Apps. [Welcome to the 2026 NASA Space Apps Challenge](#). 2026.
4. U.S. GSA. [2026 Model Context Protocol Server and AI Agent Hackathon](#). 2026.
5. The AI Conference. [The AI Conference 2026](#). 2026.
6. The AI Conference. [Day ZERO](#). 2026.
7. Stanford HAI. [Alexandr Lenk & Arvind Karunakaran: Industry Conversation with Instacart](#). 2026.
8. UC Berkeley Law Executive Education. [UC Berkeley Law AI Institute](#). 2026.
9. ODSC. [ODSC West](#). 2026.
10. HackStorm. [HackStorm Physical AI Hackathon](#). 2026.
11. Golden Gate Institute. [The Curve](#). 2026.
12. Stanford Data Science. [Empirical Methods in the Age of AI](#). 2026.
13. Stanford HAI. [Peter Norvig profile](#). accessed Sep. 9, 2026.
14. Stanford University. [Jiajun Wu profile](#). accessed Sep. 9, 2026.
15. Stanford University. [Arvind Karunakaran profile](#). accessed Sep. 9, 2026.
16. Emmanuel Ameisen. [About / ML Powered](#). accessed Sep. 9, 2026.
17. NASA Space Apps. [Los Angeles local event](#). 2026.
18. NASA Space Apps. [Irvine local event](#). 2026.

Method and limitations

Selection prioritized verified access, technical fit, deadline proximity, California relationship density, and a plausible build or conversation action. Search coverage included Bay Area, San Francisco, San Jose/Santa Clara, Stanford/Palo Alto, Berkeley, Los Angeles/Long Beach, Orange County, San Diego, Sacramento, and exceptional virtual/national/global opportunities. Public event pages change frequently; registration status and live prices should be rechecked before purchase or travel.

Prepared as an action brief, not a claim that every public event on the internet was indexed. Low-signal listings, ended events, unverifiable social posts, and opportunities without a credible participation route were excluded.